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# SLEDGING, TAMPERING AND THE UNFORGETTABLES

I'VE GOT into trouble many times, over many things, but I don't regret paying any fines or penalties for sledging. Aggression is the beauty of cricket. Trash-talking and sledging isn't very gentlemanly. But I can't imagine a more boring game if one doesn't indulge in teasing the opponents a little. Viewers like it too. But sledging should be limited to just the field. Sledging off the field? No way. Never. It's unhealthy.

I'm not an ambassador of trash-talking, but I used to like sledging more when I was younger. Now that I've sobered down, I treat the concept differently. However, there's a new lot in the Pakistan team who are really into it. But as an older/former teammate, it's my job to see that the young guys are well tutored in the dark art of tolerable sledging that's within limits – instead of getting noted by the umpires and the referee – and it gets the desired results.

Gautam Gambhir was my favourite sledging victim at one point just because of the way he talked back. So was Shane Warne. They both used to get fired up and talk right back at us, so it was always more fun with them. But I've had some embarrassing moments as well.

I remember, once we were in the middle of a bad series in Australia. We were playing a tough game and I was desperate for a win because it was my first stint as captain. Plus, we were in Perth – the wicket there is never helpful to visiting sides from the subcontinent – which didn't help in times of desperation. Pakistan was in a strong position to win but needed just a little bit of extra help with the ball. So, in front of the cameras, with millions watching, I did what's probably been done before but never captured on live television. I bit into the ball. Big, juicy bites, to dent it and make it work for us.

Here's the thing: everybody tampers with the ball. Everybody. I just showed the world how I do it without really trying to conceal it. It's that simple. I wanted to win. I like to win. And I'm sorry, very sorry, that I did it. I was emotional and hungry for a win and yes, that's why I ate the